a novel Approach




30
art
Enhance Our Urban Environment
Encourage Community Ownership and Participation
sion
ively and Liveable Singapore
lore Resource Efficient,
mpetitive & Resilient Economy

A Novel Approach

People-Private-Public – Talk about NEA's outreach efforts, or that of other government agencies, and you are bound to come up with these three "P"s. This efficient and concise term, 3P, was popularised by the very minister behind the formation of NEA, Lim Swee Say.

The term did not arise out of nowhere. In the late 1990s, the world was excited about moving into a new millennium and the 21st century. Singapore, likewise, was caught up in the enthusiasm. The government launched an exercise, aptly titled "Singapore21", to envision what Singapore could be in the next decade. Public consultations were held and task forces were set up to work on this new vision. In a parliament session on 5 June 1997, Goh Chok Tong, Prime Minister (1990 - 2004), shared his vision for Singapore21, "More than a house, Singapore must be a home ... Singapore is about people. It is only in Singapore that we, as Singaporeans, have the freedom to build the kind of environment we want to live in, work and bring up our children. That is what being an independent, sovereign nation means. In no other country will we have the same opportunity to shape a country we can be proud of. I hope that Singaporeans from all walks of life will rise to the challenges and make a difference, for Singapore and for your children."

The idea that people and partnership should take a central role in Singapore's future was reiterated in the report released by the Singapore21 committee, captured in recommendations such as this, "Active citizenship must be enlightened by commitment to the values and principles that underpin Singapore society. It paints a powerful vision of a people sector, energised by active, involved citizens, which share in the task of nation-building with the private sector and the public sector."

The notion that nation-building should involve the people, private and public sectors, struck Lim Swee Say, who was on one of the Singapore21 task forces. He recalls, "The 3P approach came from the Singapore21 exercise. One of the key takeaways is that, as the way forward for Singapore, we should adopt the 3P philosophy to engage the people, private and public sectors. That makes a lot of sense, that kind of co-ownership. So I thought, why don't we do that for the environment? If we want people to litter less, we can fine them more. If we want people to consume less water, we can charge them more. So we can use a pricing mechanism to produce short-term results. But if you really think about long-term sustainability, I think nothing is better than adopting a 3P approach."

Lim set upon pushing the approach in his new appointment at ENV straightaway. In his parliamentary speeches, he began introducing the term "3P partnership", compressing the concept of partnering people, private and public sectors into a handy phrase that would soon go viral. In office, he began urging his deputies to adopt the 3P strategy.

In many ways, it was a novel approach. Until then, ENV's primary strategy was regulation and enforcement. Its public outreach efforts were usually didactic in tone, aiming to teach and educate rather than engage. The approach was undeniably top-down.

Putting 3P partnership to action was a tough act. ENV was used to its regulatory role. When NEA formed in 2002, a major mindset shift had to be made. Lam Joon Khoi, appointed CEO of the new statutory board, remembers, "One challenge for NEA then was to nurture the public to take greater ownership of the environment. We envisioned Singapore to have a clean and healthy environment loved and cared for by everyone. We need the public to feel that they have a stake and responsibility in ensuring that our environment is kept clean. Hence, our strategy was to foster a strong collaborative partnership between NEA and the community, creating a shared ownership of the initiatives. We were mindful to balance between the enforcement and environmental promotion roles of NEA. Our focus was on the latter."

"One challenge for NEA that my team and I recognised then was to nurture the public to take greater ownership of the environment. We envisioned Singapore to have a clean and healthy environment loved and cared for by everyone. We need the public to feel that they have a stake and responsibility in ensuring that our environment is kept clean. Hence, our strategy was to foster a strong collaborative partnership between NEA and the community, creating a shared ownership of the initiatives. We were mindful to balance between the enforcement and environmental promotion roles of NEA. Our focus was on the latter."

— *Lam Joon Khoi, CEO, NEA (2002 - 2005)*



With the clear direction from the ministry, Lam began to incorporate 3P partnership in NEA's operations. Singapore was divided into six district offices under ENV for regional management of environmental health. In 2003, Lam restructured them to form regional offices aligned with the boundaries of the five Community Development Councils (CDC). The CDCs were in charge of community bonding and building social cohesiveness on the ground. This strategic move paved the way for NEA's ground operations to be integrated with grassroots initiatives.

Outreach activities were revamped to engage and empower the different sectors. The new CEO saw to it that more resources were allocated to promoting 3P efforts, and engagement of target groups such as schools was stepped up. The 3P Partnership Fund of $750,000 per year was launched in 2003 to provide seed funding for those who wish to initiate environmental projects.

When Dr Yaacob Ibrahim joined the ministry in 2004, he brought the 3P strategy to a higher level with his extensive experience working with the community during his previous post at the Ministry of Community Development and Sports (present-day Ministry of Community Development, Youth and Sports). He says, "Bringing people on our side was, I thought, very important. The message is, 'This is your environment. You have to take care of it together with us and let's work together.' So we engaged the NGOs (non-governmental organisations). And it was something that we were a bit uneasy about in the early days. But we soon realised that if we didn't get the people and NGOs on our side, we were going to have a big problem in bringing the whole nation together to talk about sustainable development."







Operationally, 3P partnership efforts received an even bigger boost under NEA's second CEO, Lee Yuen Hee, who joined in 2005. More resources were provided for such efforts on the ground. The 3P partnership department in NEA was raised to the level of a division to accord its work the rightful significance. "At that time, the 3P partnership approach was already recognised and embraced as the key to NEA achieving its mission. The 3P partnership force was further beefed up and provided with the resources needed to carry out its work," shares Lee. "Another important component was outreach to the young in kindergartens, schools, polytechnics and tertiary institutions. It is only through inculcating our people with the right environmental values from young that we can hope to build and sustain the pro-environmental mindset."

Partnership with the different sectors became more focused during the term of NEA's third CEO, Andrew Tan, who joined in 2009. Programmes were devised to specially target specific groups. For instance, creative initiatives such as music and fashion competitions with an environmental focus were organised to draw young Singaporeans. The flagship environmental event for youths, Youth for the Environment Day, was launched with a bang in 2011.

After a decade of focused efforts, the 3P partnership strategy has successfully become a key thrust in NEA's mission. That said, balancing the duty to regulate and the mission to partner the community is still a fine act. As Dr Vivian Balakrishnan, who took up office as Minister for the Environment and Water Resources in 2011, puts it, "The challenge is that we need to maintain our standards, and have the public and NEA working collectively. We cannot afford to have an adversarial relationship between NEA officers on the ground and the public. What we need is a partnership."

But clearly, within NEA itself, a mindset shift had taken place. For an agency which started out with strict enforcement as its key approach, NEA now sees partnership as important as its regulatory role. Its strong network on the ground with grassroots organisations, schools, NGOs and private corporations testify to how far the 3P partnership strategy has come. As for whether this can eventually bring about Singapore's long-term sustainability, it now depends on how Singapore evolves as a community. Andrew Tan summarises, "We cannot be everywhere all the time. The more philosophical question is, do we want to be everywhere all the time? We want to move towards a society where people take on greater responsibility and we can work together with the community than work against the community. It depends on how Singapore evolves. We want to move towards a more promotional, facilitator mode of engagement rather than enforcement. But we can only do that if everyone plays their part. And the public still wants the authorities to take irresponsible members to task. It is a balance we have to strike. We are conscious of these two roles. For NEA officers, working in NEA, we are in this job to make a difference. We are here to safeguard the environment and we also have a role to educate Singaporeans and get them to be more responsible citizens."


MAKE YOUR
COMMITMENT
TO THE

In The Heartlands

Going down to the district level to manage public health and environmental issues is a strategy that has been used since colonial times. What marks the difference today is the level of participation from the ground. NEA's regional offices not only see to the effective management of public health and the environment, they also partner the communities around them to come up with ideas and projects of their own. Every community has different needs, and these needs can differ vastly from one community to the other. Working with the very people who live there ensures that the environmental initiatives are relevant for the community.

At housing estates in Pasir Ris and Punggol, some 250 volunteers from the grassroots formed a strike force against mosquitoes. Banding together with NEA officers, the strike force covered more than 3,000 residences in August 2011 to drive home the dengue prevention message. The participation from the ground was vital as active dengue clusters were found at Pasir Ris Street 12.

Over at the five community development districts, NEA officers sat down with community leaders and facilitators from grassroots organisations and the CDCs to work out their respective environmental plans and programmes.

These volunteers and community leaders make the all-important difference in NEA's outreach efforts. Carefully nurtured over the years, the relationships between NEA and the grassroots were further cemented during national crises such as SARS in 2003 and Singapore's worst dengue epidemic in 2005, when hundreds of volunteers rallied with NEA to combat the outbreaks.

When NEA's district offices were realigned to the same boundaries as the CDCs, the move paved the way for the agency to show the grassroots that they could work towards common goals. Public and environmental health projects were shown to be effective in producing a higher standard of living for residents and nurturing community bonds. The mayors of the five CDCs supported the move wholeheartedly and took the lead to integrate the environment as a core component in their plans for the community districts.

In addition, NEA trains and guides grassroots volunteers, equipping them with the skills and knowledge to run the programmes on their own. Recycling days, environmental and public health workshops and seminars, and energy conservation campaigns are just some of the usual activities run by these volunteers. The agency supports the grassroots by providing exhibits, educational kits and collaterals. It also supplies intelligence on locations of dengue clusters when outbreaks take place.









Clockwise from top left: Exciting and creative initiatives such as the Eco Music Challenge galvanise Singapore's youths to act for the environment; The Envirobot spreads environmental messages through interactive means; Volunteers from the community go house to house to promote activities such as recycling; Operation MACE injects an environmental lesson in gaming, as participants take down mosquitoes in this first-person-shoot-out game.

A PLAN FOR EVERY DISTRICT

There is the overarching mission to encourage green lifestyles, and there are specific strategies when one gets to the ground. Today, the environment is an essential feature in the CDCs' plans for their districts. But instead of a one-size-fits-all approach, every district has a long-term plan tailored to its specific needs. These plans, developed jointly by NEA and the CDCs, are the result of consultations with grassroots organisations, schools, corporate partners, town councils, voluntary welfare organisations and members of the community.

"Clean City, Enviro-Friendly Lifestyle, Green Community"

The Central district of Singapore is the most diverse in terms of population profile. As such, NEA and Central Singapore CDC use common goals of residents to build unity and bonds within the community. This gives rise to the tagline for the 10-year Central Singapore Environmental Sustainability Plan launched in 2009 – "Clean City, Enviro-Friendly Lifestyle, Green Community". "Clean City" aims to achieve the cultivation of good social and hygiene habits, while "Enviro-Friendly Lifestyle" seeks to educate residents to adopt green practices such as saving energy and practising the 3Rs (Reduce, Reuse, Recycle). "Green Community" provides avenues and platforms for all stakeholders to contribute and create a green movement in the district.

"Actions by the Community for the Environment"

Community ownership is underscored when it comes to North East district's green plan, aptly entitled "ACE Plan" (Actions by the Community for the Environment). The North East ACE Plan aims to raise public awareness and garner support from the community to sustain a clean and green environment in the North East district. This district's five-year work plan, which came into effect in 2009, takes a topical approach. "Clean Environment", "Resource Conservation", "Energy Efficiency", "Encouraging More Community Efforts" and "Creating a Sustainable Green Future" make up the five core objectives of the plan.

"Green Living @ North West"

Promoting community bonding and social cohesion, cultivating a green lifestyle, increasing environmental ownership and achieving environmental sustainability outline the objectives of North West district's 10-year ECO Plan, Green Living @ North West. The plan, launched in 2009, is supported by five pillars comprising "Clean Every Day", "LEAD Everyone Against Dengue", "Fight Climate Change", "3Rs" and "Clean Toilets". North West CDC targets to build the largest green network in the district by 2014 with 45 community green clubs and 2,000 volunteers to reach out to 90,000 households under Recycle @ North West, launched in 2011.

"Go Green @ South East"

South East district's GreenPlan is an all-out call for the community to "Go Green". This five-year plan launched in 2010 identifies the key groups in its district – green schools, green homes, green grassroots and green organisations, and their roles in protecting the environment in areas such as dengue management, energy-saving and resource conservation. What's interesting about the plan is its "T-model". The horizontal bar of the "T" represents the broad-based approach to reach out and involve as many people as possible to do a small part for the environment. The vertical bar symbolises the strategy to engage interest groups and organisations for more in-depth projects.

"Tomorrow Starts Today"

Over at the South West district, the environment and community are inseparable when it comes to long-term planning. Which is why its 10-year plan for the district is called ECo Plan, i.e. Environment & Community Plan. Released in 2009, the plan emphasises building sustainable and engaged communities in a cleaner, greener and healthier home for its residents. Five key thrusts are formulated to develop the district into a cool, green, clean, caring and pro-active community. Targets for the district include reducing energy consumption by 10%, instilling a higher level of social graciousness in the area of adopting good public health and hygiene practices, planting a million native plants and encouraging more residents to volunteer.











CHAT WITH A MAYOR

Dr Amy Khor, whose passion for the environment is well-known, has contributed to a better, more sustainable Singapore through her former posting in MEWR. She shares her thoughts as the Mayor of South West District, a post she has held since 2004.

Having been actively involved in policy-making and issues related to the environment for so many years, could you share with us your perspectives on how the scene has changed over the years?

Four decades ago, way before sustainability became a catchphrase, we were already pursuing it as one of our goals. It was out of sheer necessity that we had to pursue water and environmental sustainability. Through judicious land planning, investment in environmental infrastructure, strict legislation on pollution control and close partnership with the people, private and public sectors, we have built for ourselves a clean and green city that is in harmony with good economic growth.

In 2008, the Inter-Ministerial Committee on Sustainable Development was set up to develop a national framework and key strategies for Singapore's sustainable development for the next two decades. We widely consulted key stakeholders and the public. We received over 1,300 suggestions and more than 700 people participated to contribute their ideas and aspirations to a sustainable Singapore. I am heartened that corporate and community organisations and civic-minded individuals are increasingly taking a keen interest to be part of this co-creation process.

In recent years, we see more organisations contributing towards the environment as part of their corporate social responsibility. More volunteers are stepping forward every year to champion various environmental causes. In South West district alone, we see a steady increase in the engagement of participants and volunteers in the environmental programmes.

With your years of working with NEA, what are your views on the agency's work over the last decade?

As the national agency devoted to environmental issues, NEA has played a crucial role for Singapore's development, and I am proud of it. One of the key changes I witnessed was NEA's active efforts to engage a greater number and wider spread of partners to attain a higher level of buy-in for environmental causes. As a matter of fact, NEA had foresight and was progressive when it established decentralised regional offices to be closer to the ground and work with the community.

When NEA was formed in 2002, it was heir to three decades of hard work undertaken by ENV (present-day MEWR) since 1972. Over the last decade, NEA has focused on shaping lifestyles and habits by engaging the 3P partners more fully and empowering them.

However, the work for the environment is never done. NEA's work is not easy as the challenges faced by the agency run from everyday issues like ensuring clean public toilets and littering to more complex ones like climate change and trans-boundary haze. In a changing social, economic and geopolitical landscape, the target is always moving, and NEA must stay ahead of these trends to remain relevant. It has done commendably well in this regard.



As the Mayor of South West District, can you share with us your thoughts on the district's green plan?

Through the South West CDC's 10-year ECo (Environment & Community) Plan, we aspire to build sustainable and engaged communities, and create a healthier, cleaner and greener home. We also hope that the community will take ownership of the environment, thus building a sense of belonging.

Hence, it is imperative that the community be involved in the co-creation of our plan, right from the stage of conceptualisation. We had a committee formed, made up of very passionate people, from both the private and public sectors, to spearhead the plan's creation, coupled with comprehensive consultation with the community.

These goals then provided the direction for our environmental programmes. For instance, our youth volunteers are trained to raise awareness and inculcate the values of energy efficiency, waste recycling and water conservation in our residents through house-to-house visits.

Additionally, local green plans and programmes must dovetail with national efforts to create a sustainable Singapore. It is in this spirit that we mooted the 10-year plan in 2008 and launched our climate change strategy in 2011 to support the meeting of Singapore's 2020 target to reduce carbon emissions.

We recognise that we can do more for the environment and the community when we synergise and pool our resources together. I am glad that NEA (South West Regional Office) has a dedicated 3P partnership team. Their expertise in environmental issues and programmes has been integral in the success of our efforts. They act as an enabler, as they provide training for volunteers and deploy them in various programmes to engage the community.

THE COMMUNITY GOES GREEN!



"Whenever residents in Canberra see anything that may cause pollution or lead to breeding of mosquitoes, they can call and I will follow up. We patrol the different precincts and note anything that needs improvement. For example, when NEA rolled out recycling bins in our area in 2006, many residents thought they were big waste bins. So we gathered volunteers to stand by the bins, educated residents on recycling and encouraged them to share the information with their families and friends. I also run a emailing list compiling daily updates on dengue fever and clusters from NEA's website. I use the network to pass on new environmental messages as well. If everyone does just a little bit for the environment, it can make a difference. One small group of people can influence people around them and the next generation to change the environment."

Peter Lo, retiree, has been recruiting and training volunteers for environmental causes in Canberra since 2003. Together with the volunteers, he drives initiatives such as recycling projects and patrols to battle mosquito breeding.



"Our first collaborative effort with NEA in raising environmental awareness in Mountbatten was an event in 2007 encouraging everyone to adopt the '3Rs' in their lifestyles. Its success encouraged me greatly. Since then we have worked with NEA to create awareness on environmental issues during our activities. I hope to persuade more residents to take part in our green initiatives by organising events that are creative. During our Mountbatten Commemorates Earth Hour event in 2012, we used minimal lighting and electricity, and the half-lit stage came alive through creative events, such as youths performing beat-boxing and a cappella. It is important that we should all make a concerted effort to save our environment, for our generation and for generations to come. When we see residents engaged through our outlets, it is certainly a wonderful affirmation of the good work we have done for the community."

Amatul Jameel Suhani (A J Suhani Sujari), teacher, is an active grassroots leader raising awareness on environmental issues among her community in Mountbatten.



"I really want to see our children grow up in a clean, healthy environment. The SARS and dengue outbreaks have shown us that we should take care of the environment and our hygiene. It is not easy to convince people to practise the right habits, such as getting rid of stagnant water to prevent mosquito breeding. We conduct house visits often to make sure that the environmental messages get through, and we distribute brochures from NEA to residents. NEA officers work very closely with us, especially in terms of projects for the environment. Making sure that our residents benefit from the projects and helping them understand what we are trying to do so that one day they will appreciate it and practise responsible habits to protect themselves and their loved ones – this is what drives me. After all these years, we can see things changing. People are becoming more aware now, especially when it comes to dengue prevention."

Raja Mohan, who works in a charitable home, has been advocating good hygiene and cleanliness in his community at Hougang since the SARS outbreak in 2003. Besides organising environment events with his fellow grassroots volunteers, he also shares the message through talks and presentations on cleanliness.



"We come up with interactive ways to spread the environmental message, such as games and skits. For example, we enact situations where a litterbug is caught in the act and how passers-by react. This gets the attention of the residents, who learn about taking initiative to stop littering. NEA works very closely with us to drive and visualise our ideas. The past four years of initiatives have definitely led to some changes. When I set off for work at 7 am, I would go round the back of my building. It used to be chocked with litter. But now the ground is much cleaner. Personally, when I see that the estate is clean, and when residents tell me that our events are really educational, it is rewarding. Every word and compliment from residents encourage and motivate me to do more."

Alice Tavamani, an executive in the aerospace industry, strives passionately with her fellow grassroots leaders to enhance the environment at Boon Lay, from dengue prevention and stopping littering to energy conservation.

Opposite: NEA officers get down to the ground to encourage households to conserve energy, one light bulb at a time.


CLEAN
GREEN

CLEAN AND GREEN SINGAPORE

A look at how NEA's flagship environmental event has grown over the years

From a week-long event to a campaign which lasts a year, Clean and Green Singapore has undergone a radical transformation since it began in 1990 under ENV as Clean and Green Week. This campaign has always been a significant event on the national agenda – the fact that it is always launched by either the Prime Minister or the Deputy Prime Ministers underscores its importance. Held during either October or November every year, the campaign started out as an attempt to instil awareness and appreciation of a clean and green environment among Singaporeans. When NEA took over Clean and Green Week in 2002, it immediately took steps to refresh the campaign. More partners were invited to co-create the events and more activities were launched. And the question arose – why slate a week for Singapore to be clean and green? Why not a campaign that called for a clean and green Singapore through the year? Clean and Green Singapore was thus born. Today, the campaign covers a diverse range of topics, from protecting the environment and climate change to public health and hygiene. Over the years, the involvement of the 3P sectors has also grown steadily. The result – a Clean and Green Singapore that is better, bigger and way more vibrant than ever!

2002 The first Clean and Green Week organised by NEA, its focus was on resource conservation. A noteworthy highlight of the week was an exhibition co-organised with Central Singapore CDC, on different ways to reduce, reuse and recycle. This is a key step in the strengthening of partnerships between NEA and the CDCs.

2003 The SARS crisis just blew over. But the lessons were not forgotten. Hence, the theme "We Care, We're Ok" for the year's Clean and Green Week was adopted from NEA's Singapore's OK campaign for higher standards of public health and hygiene. This was the first time such issues took central stage in the week-long event.

2004 NEA jointly organised the event with a CDC, South West CDC, for the first time. It was an important milestone in NEA's efforts to nurture community ownership of the environment. Singapore's OK continued to be the theme for the event to encourage more social responsibility and graciousness. With the launch of "Adopt-a-school" programme, the carnival for schools held during the week was to become more exciting from 2004 onwards.

2005 Nurturing environmental ownership continued to be a primary thrust during the event. The Schools' Carnival during the week proved to be more vibrant than ever as schools took to designing games, competitions and quizzes revolving around environmental topics.

2006 This was the last year in which the event was named Clean and Green Week. From 2007 onwards, it would be known as Clean and Green Singapore. Instead of a week-long event to create more awareness, NEA decided to turn it into a year-long commitment to keeping Singapore clean and green. All the other various campaigns under NEA would fall under the bigger umbrella of Clean and Green Singapore. This would inspire Singaporeans to be environmentally friendly not just for a week, but for each day of the week.

2007 Clean and Green Singapore campaign was launched, marking a new era for NEA's campaigns for environmental sustainability. The planning of environmental events became more cohesive and systematic now that they were seen as part of a larger campaign. Changing the mindsets of Singaporeans on a daily basis also became more prominent in this newly-refreshed event, with the theme "Adopting an Environmentally-Friendly Lifestyle".

2008 The campaign aimed at encouraging Singaporeans to be more conscious of the environment on a daily basis. NEA continued to co-organise the event with external partners, including South East CDC, PUB and NParks. The agency also took care to make the carnival a low-carbon event.

2009 40 years of Singapore's clean and green journey were celebrated at the year's campaign. Singapore's progress and development over the past four decades were traced in an exhibition. Efforts to inspire and empower the community continued to be stepped up through the diverse events organised by NEA and its partners.

2010 Sustainability became a buzzword with the launch of the Sustainable Development Blueprint in 2009. Clean and Green Singapore supported the message of the blueprint. Events were planned and designed to bring forth the importance of personal responsibility in creating a sustainable Singapore.

2011 Community pride and ownership of the environment remained a key focus. NEA also launched two new flagship events – The community-led "Keep Singapore Clean" and "Youth for the Environment Day" to mobilise Singapore's youths to be more involved in environmental causes.



"Through all our initiatives over the years, we have progressively transformed Singapore into a City of Gardens and of Water. Looking ahead, we must learn to develop sustainably as well. The government is coming up with programmes, but these programmes need support from the people sector and the private sector to make them work. I am confident that we can achieve our goals by working together so let us put our efforts together, do it cohesively and ensure a clean and green Singapore for many generations to come."

— Lee Hsien Loong, Prime Minister, at the launch of Clean and Green Singapore 2010, 30 October 2009





NEA 3P officers are the drivers and movers in engaging the community to act for the environment. They work closely with the local communities to create and plan long-term initiatives, and set targets for a better environment. They encourage and support residents, schools, grassroots organisations and corporations to come up with exciting projects of their own. As facilitators, they help different groups of passionate advocates for the environment to connect and network with each other for greater synergy in their initiatives. 3P officers are also posted to every community district, where they have a strong presence on the ground, nurturing generations of Singaporeans to care for and cherish the environment they live in.





Youths For The Environment

Recognising the pivotal role of the youths in shaping a better environment, NEA takes exceptional care to reach out to youths in ways that are relevant and fresh, so as to nurture a strong sense of environmental ownership.



"Let's keep it clean, green, beautiful, Like Heaven on Earth, We'll get by with the simple things in life, We'll give it what it's worth ..." so croons Haramain Osman in a self-composed ode to the environment at the Eco Music Challenge 2011 organised by NEA.

Haramain Osman is one of the many youths inspired by NEA's initiatives to put his creativity to use for Planet Earth. Music challenges, fashion shows of designs that use recyclable materials, climate change photography competitions, creating sculptures from urban waste – these are just some of the exciting things concocted by NEA to galvanise youths for the environmental cause.

Recognising the pivotal role of youths in shaping a better environment, NEA takes exceptional care to reach out to youths in ways that are relevant and fresh, so as to nurture a strong sense of environmental ownership.

Not only that, principals and teachers are joining the cause as well. Today, the environmental movement is picking up at schools around Singapore. Every school has a teacher who doubles as the Environmental Education Advisor, trained by NEA, to plan and coordinate environmental programmes and incorporate environmental issues in the students' learning process. Environment or green clubs are also springing up in schools, birthing grounds for future environmental champions. This network took the agency years of work to build up, by working with principals and teachers on a school-by-school basis, and consultations with the Ministry of Education.

The firm foundation with the schools made it possible for NEA's flagship environmental platform for youths, Youth for the Environment Day (YED), to be created. Launched in 2011, YED falls on Earth Day, 22 April, every year. Young Singaporeans can champion environmental ownership and renew their commitment to care for their environment on that day, and take part in a wide range of programmes such as recycling drives, energy conservation, clean-up of their surroundings and workshops on environmental issues.




UTH FOR THE
ENVIRONMENT DAY
Launch of
YOUTH FOR THE
ENVIRONMENT DAY
Guest-of-Honour: Dr Yaacob Ibrahim, Minister for the Environment and Water Resources
2011
ECOFRIEND
AWARDS
CEREMONY

GROOMING STEWARDS OF THE ENVIRONMENT

Step into any school today and chances are that you will meet budding environmental champions busy with recycling drives, dengue prevention programmes or designing experiments on environmental solutions.

The green movement among the young is making waves, starting from the schools. Principals and teachers are now more and more involved in integrating environmental education with student life. Koh-Leong Swee Ling, the teacher co-ordinating environmental education in Dunman High School, explains the importance, "The situation in this world today is such that sustainability is a real issue. We do need to teach our children so that they adopt a green lifestyle and they know the concern about resources. To prepare them to achieve sustainability in the long run, they need to be educated on the environment. They need to have the passion to find out more, to innovate and to find solutions. It is vital for our students to have environmental education."

These views are echoed by many educators. Incorporating environmental issues into the schools' curriculum and activities also help to achieve the bigger mission of student development. Chong Chee Wee, the teacher in charge of the green club at Anchor Green Primary School, shares, "We want to build character in our pupils, and through the platform of environmental education, they can learn to be gracious citizens."

The surge in such awareness came about thanks to NEA's 3P partnership with the schools. The agency promotes environmental education, provides resources and training for educators, tailors events from workshops to competitions and ties schools up with private companies for environmental initiatives. "NEA provides many avenues for students and teachers, such as the Environmental Champion workshops and Environmental Education Advisor networking sessions, to provide training and learning opportunities to further develop environmental advocates. Through the networking sessions and provision of funding and resources, we are able to better align our programmes with NEA's agenda," shares Annie Lim, Senior Teacher for Environmental Education at Commonwealth Secondary School. "Our long-standing partnership with NEA has been invaluable and instrumental in developing the green agenda within the school and community. Being involved in the maturing and growth of NEA's programmes has propelled the school's progress. We are recognised as the centre for environmental education among schools in the west zone and in 2009, we were the first school to receive the President's Award for the Environment. We anticipate closer collaboration as we work together in nurturing the next generation of environmental stewards, advocates and guardians."

With the resources and support from NEA, the schools go on to create a myriad of activities, such as school fairs, green competitions, workshops and classroom learning sessions covering topics from dengue prevention to energy conservation, eco-camps and hands-on projects.

What is most encouraging is the fact that schools are beginning to see a mindset change taking place among the students. For example, at Dunman High School, students used to complain about having to use recycling bins. In recent years, students have switched to complaining about improper use of recycling bins. Anchor Green Primary School no longer sees the need to remind its students that Wednesday is recycling day, as they have internalised the message. Anglo-Chinese School (Independent) teacher, See Boon Tiam, says, "The viewing rate of exhibitions on the environment has gone up, now they create quite a buzz among the students. Our green club started with only 14 members and now it's over 100 strong. There are also more and more student-initiated projects."

Summing it up, Lim Bin, teacher-in-charge of Woodgrove Secondary School's green club, says, "We really appreciate the opportunities and trust given by NEA. The platform it provides for the students is not something you can find in textbooks."

"Sometimes when you teach the students, they may or may not internalise everything they are taught, such as taking care of the environment. But perhaps years later, they will recall and connect what they were taught when they were young to their present, and make a difference."

– Lim Bin, teacher, Woodgrove Secondary School






END
COASTER

Under NEA's Corporate And School Partnership (CASP) programme, companies can partner schools on different levels, from sponsorship and mentoring students to internships and even implementing customised larger-scale programmes.



Launch of Environment Champions Industry Module for students in 2010, a collaborative effort between NEA and Panasonic.

MORE THAN BUSINESS

Since the Industrial Revolution in the 19th century, the relationship between businesses and the environment has never quite been amicable. Thankfully, this is changing as industries and corporations mature and begin to take on social responsibility in caring for the environment. In Singapore, NEA plays a central role to facilitate the private sector in their corporate social responsibility initiatives.

Under ENV and later on NEA, working relationships with the private sector have always existed. What marks the change today is a growing partnership. "In the past, engagement with the private sector was operationally driven. We consult them in terms of policy changes, how to roll out and smoothen the implementation," says Tan Wee Hock, Director of the 3P Network Division in NEA. "Now, we leverage quite strongly on the private sector to educate the young and the community. The private sector has resources to help certain groups. They can provide manpower to mentor youths and funds to sponsor programmes. It is quite important, because some of the companies can develop environmental programmes and go out and do a lot of good work. They also have expertise to interest the young in areas such as developing clean energy. They can develop flagship programmes to further spread the message. This is what we mean by engaging the private sector now."

To cater to different levels of involvement from the private sector, NEA has developed a range of programmes. Getting the private sector to raise funds for environmental causes and NGOs is an important component of NEA's strategy. A key fund-raising event is the annual Semakau Run, organised at Semakau Landfill by NEA to encourage corporate giving. Since its launch in 2007, the Semakau Run has raised more than $1.8 million. The funds benefited environmental NGOs and social service charities with pledges made by participating companies.

Today, after a decade of facilitating private sector partnership, NEA has small and medium enterprises and large corporations taking part in its 3P programmes. More importantly, greater synergy for the environment is created as NEA helps to bridge the private and people sectors.

"Traditionally, we have been focusing on safeguarding, ensuring that we continue to enjoy a high standard of environment. If you look at the history of NEA, besides the infrastructural development, the enforcement role is actually quite central. Enforcement definitely has an impact. First of all, if most people abide by the rules, and some of them don't, and they are not punished, it defeats the purpose. After a while, it erodes the whole social contract. Therefore enforcement against the minority who are offenders and bringing them to task is critical. Secondly, when you enforce, it still does have an impact of converting offenders. For example, during Corrective Work Order, they will realise the impact caused by their actions, for the simple fact that they have made the life of the sweeper more difficult and it's not trivial. But when we move towards green issues, that's where enforcement may not be the best model. To encourage people to recycle, if we just enforce, we may get results. It will work up to a certain extent, but do we have the resources to sustain it all the time if we make it mandatory? We cannot be everywhere all the time, it's not feasible. That's where we think, at the end of the day, the people must take ownership. Basically a lot of our work is changing behaviour. We want to create social pressure. Just like queuing. If you jump queues, people will stare at you. So going forward, we have to leverage more on public consultations and discussions. Ultimately, if you look at our programmes, we used to be driving towards a clean and green Singapore. Now we want to move towards a clean and green Singaporean. If you are a clean and green Singaporean, you will always do the right thing, it doesn't matter where you are. This is the set of values you will exhibit."

— Tan Wee Hock, Director, 3P Network Division, NEA



A CARNIVAL OF PARTNERSHIPS

Under NEA's Corporate And School Partnership (CASP) programme, companies partner schools to further the environmental cause. A cornerstone of NEA's outreach to schools and the private sector, the programme was previously known as "Adopt-a-school" when it was launched in 2004. Through the CASP programme, companies can ramp up on their corporate social responsibility initiatives by supporting environmentally minded youths. Schools and students also benefit through the funds, advice and mentorship provided by the companies. The students are also exposed to real situations and scenarios first-hand, such as using clean energy in industrial settings.

The partnerships culminate in the annual two-day Schools' Carnival. This national platform exhibits the joint projects by students and the companies. Converting waste heat into electricity and using hydrogen cells to power vehicles, coming up with new ways to use old things, designing environmental education kits and organising eco-camps – students embark on a journey of learning and discovery and put in their best shot for the environment.





BECAUSE THEY ARE OUR FUTURE

It is a power plant, yet it has received accolades for its environmental initiatives, among which are its school outreach programmes. Each year, Senoko Energy allocates resources for environmental projects with students. For example, through its National Weather Study Project which involves more than 150 schools, students are educated on climate change and encouraged to launch research initiatives.

Senoko Energy is in this for a good reason. "We are conscious of the impact we have on the environment and the community. It is our business to be a good neighbour and that means care for the environment and community engagement are a priority on our agenda," explains Kwong Kok Chan, General Manager.

On its own, Senoko Energy has been consistently adopting best practices in environmental protection in its operations. But building internal capacity alone is not enough.

Says Kwong, "We wanted to engage the schools as well as the community and even NGOs. When NEA approached us in 2004, asking us if we were interested to adopt schools for environmental initiatives, it was the chance we were waiting for. And immediately, we said, 'Yes.' We would adopt all the schools in our neighbourhood."

Following the breakthrough, Senoko Energy went on to build strong collaborative networks with the schools. Today, it shares expert knowledge on clean energy, mentors and funds student projects, influences the schools' curriculum for environmental education and organises internships.

The resources pumped into Senoko's outreach programmes are considerable. Just the National Weather Study Project alone called for millions in funding. Senoko's staff also volunteer regularly at different schools. But to the company, the returns are immeasurable. "We have benefitted immensely," asserts Kwong. "We have seen some really imaginative projects by the students and we have also learnt new things along the way. But the main objective is also how we can add value to the learning journey of the students, because they are our future. Through NEA, we have worked out a very meaningful programme to build bridges in the community, make the first step into the schools and make a difference."

IT'S FOR A CAUSE

For Wah & Hua, it all started with the line they are in. "We have been collecting tonnes of rubbish every day," Marcus Koo, Business Development Manager, says. "And we have been thinking, how do we push this further – cutting down the waste volume at source."

Starting at source means engaging with the community, so as to spread the message of minimising waste. "It was fortunate that NEA shared with us the opportunity to work with schools," recalls Koo. "Without NEA, we wouldn't have this opportunity. We've got to give credit to NEA that in these few years, rather than just enforcement, they are also building bridges, and linking people with the private sector."

Being a small enterprise, Wah & Hua employs an innovative approach to educate students. "We give talks. We do presentations and teach students about recycling. But more importantly, we engage the students creatively," Koo highlights. "I bring the students to our facility. We collect industrial



waste, so there are a lot of materials that can be re-used. We get the students to conceptualise art projects and pick their materials from the waste. This gives waste a new lease of life. And for all our projects, we don't spend a single cent!"

And happily, the students get to unleash their creativity too, as they experiment with using waste, learn about the value of resources and become more conscious of the waste management issues faced by Singapore. Wah & Hua also shares its knowledge of waste management, recycling tips and industrial knowledge with the schools.

"It's for a cause," summarises Koo. "Doing things for the environment is not about profit. A lot of people think that we need to do very big projects to help the environment. But each of us just needs to change a little habit, like recycling, and the environment can improve a lot. So you never know who you are going to benefit. Hopefully we can spread the message, and more people will join in."

WE LIVE IN AN INTER-DEPENDENT WORLD

Even before corporate social responsibility became a global business trend, real estate developer, City Developments Limited (CDL), had started on this track more than 15 years ago when it adopted environmental protection as a key pillar in its business strategy during the mid-1990s.

Says Esther An, General Manager of Corporate Affairs and Head of CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility), "We are all living in an inter-dependent world. One cannot draw a clear line between a business, the community and the environment. To achieve business excellence, we have to do well not only financially, but also in the community and the environmental aspects."

Outreach is a key element in CDL's environmental efforts to achieve buy-in from stakeholders and change behaviour. Since the 1990s, it has been actively working with ENV. Apart from proactively engaging its supply chain to track and improve environmental performance at work sites, CDL has also initiated environmental projects such as Project: Eco-Office in 2002 and One Degree Up Campaign in 2007 etc. Today, CDL's efforts range from engaging its tenants and homebuyers and NGOs to collaborating with schools under NEA's CASP programme. "Apart from funding their projects, we work closely with teachers and students on eco-projects that benefit the students and the environment," An recounts.

Over time, NEA and CDL have nurtured a strong working relationship. An puts it this way, "To us, NEA is not just a government agency; it's a partner. When we talk to our tenants on our green initiatives for example, with NEA's support, there's a stamp of trust and confidence that it is a public-private engagement. And we have worked together on many projects such as NEA's 10% Energy Challenge and Semakau Run. In the past, when we started out on Clean and Green Week, there wasn't so much public-private sector collaboration. But now, NEA is working to engage not only the corporate sector, but also the grassroots, the community centres, the academics and the schools. I'd say that NEA has done a very good job in encouraging and supporting the corporate sector and the community to drive and take on environmental initiatives."

The Word Is "Ownership"

The key to change is "ownership", when we see the environment as ours to safeguard and cherish. When we see it as a norm that every individual takes responsibility for ensuring long-term sustainability. NEA's 3P partnership efforts, networks and communication efforts have come a long way in nurturing this change in Singaporeans.

Enforcement and regulation can only go so far in achieving long-term environmental sustainability. The government cannot be everywhere to make sure we follow rules, and it would take too much resources. The question of keeping public areas clean is a pertinent example. Every year, the government spends millions on keeping our streets, roads and public areas free from litter. In 2006, the bill was a hefty $36 million. By 2010, the figure had risen to $50 million. The amount can be cut down considerably if we do not litter in the first place.

To push the transformation further, the agency has mounted schemes to facilitate a sense of ownership in the people, private and public sectors.

The 3P Partnership Fund uses co-funding to enable any organisation or company registered in Singapore to carry out environmental projects which engage schools, the private sector or the community-at-large. These projects are conceptualised and undertaken by the applicants.

The other strategy adopted by NEA is to nurture "change-makers". Through the programmes it runs, NEA identifies individuals who are passionate about the environment, and further equips them with skills and knowledge to do more. These individuals go on to spark change in their community, be it the workplace, home or school.

The Environment Champion programme, inaugurated in 2004, is a case in point. The programme consists of modules covering a wide range of topics. In 2005, the programme was extended from schools to private and public organisations. For the corporate environment champions, the modules impart know-how on planning and implementing environmental programmes, such as minimising wastage of paper, electricity and ensuring good hygiene in the work place. The champions also learn to conduct basic self-audits to gauge the performance of their pro-environment initiatives.

Forging ahead, NEA's Youth Environment Envoy programme was launched in 2005 to complement the Environment Champion movement. Youths who are keen to become leaders of change can apply to be trained as Youth Environment Envoys. To empower these youths, NEA holds workshops to enhance their public speaking, networking, facilitation and project management skills to prepare them for leadership. These young envoys will then move on to start projects of their own to contribute towards Singapore's environmental sustainability.

In the venture to support environmental ownership, NEA collaborates with NGOs which advocate the same causes. The support comes in different forms, such as funding, partnership and using NEA's communication platforms to promote certain initiatives. For example, the agency supports the Singapore Environment Council in its effort to champion a greener workplace and schools through its various awards and audit programmes. NEA also partners the Restroom Association of Singapore to encourage a clean toilet culture among toilet owners and users by endorsing the association's programmes.

The work to effect change is a never-ending task. Since its inception, the 3P Partnership Fund has grown to $1.5 million. Schools, community groups and NGOs have since created and launched diverse programmes as a result of the funding. Environment Champions now advocate in private and public organisations and in their community. Annual surveys on 3P Partnership programmes have shown positive reception towards NEA's initiatives and support. These are important steps towards a vision of Singapore in which each and every one of us claims ownership of our environment.



THIS IS MY PASSION

Pop by any green event in Ang Mo Kio or Hougang, and chances are you would run into this unassuming young man, working behind the scenes with volunteers.

Ong Chee Siang is a familiar face around his neighbourhood. He chairs the local youth club, champions environmental causes, mentors students, brainstorms and drives community projects with volunteers and helps out regularly at charitable organisations. This is a far cry from the wayward boy who once aspired to be the best gangster in Singapore. Two years in a boys' home changed his perspectives.

Giving back to the community was at the top of his mind when he left the boys' home in 1998, and volunteer work became a daily affair for him. Championing environmental causes entered the picture later, when a dengue outbreak took place in 2004. "The incident was so impactful that I told myself, I must do something for the environment. NEA was running dengue prevention programmes then, and I decided to take part," Ong recalls.

His interest in environmental issues grew as he became more involved in programmes run by NEA, and took part in the Youth Environment Envoy (YEE) programme launched in 2005. Soon, his interest infected the other members of the youth group he chaired, Ci Yuan Community Club (CC) Youth Club. "I thought to myself, why don't I focus on the environment, and use it to bond the community?" Ong shares.

Led by Ong, Ci Yuan CC Youth Club went on to push for a greener lifestyle in their community. A project in 2007 saw the club manning a station in Hougang to collect recyclables from residents, who welcomed the move. This convinced Chee Siang to persuade the public waste collector of the area to provide recycling bins for every two blocks in his neighbourhood. Seminars, workshops and activities relating to the environment were organised regularly as well.

The club was game to take on large-scale projects too, such as working with NEA in 2009 to organise the biggest youth-initiated environment project in Singapore – the National Youth EnvirOlympics. For a group of youths who had little experience in organising large-scale events, it was a challenging feat. "We had meetings till midnight with NEA staff in the Environment Building!" laughs Chee Siang. "The staff guided us step by step, and showed us how to manage the project. I was very motivated when I saw them staying up with us and putting in so much effort."

Launching project after project for the environment is only part of what Chee Siang does, who devotes a large part of his time working with youths as well. To reach out to them effectively, he forms interest groups within the youth club, each focusing on a different aspect of environmental sustainability such as recycling, community engagement and biodiversity. On his days off from work, he shuttles between several schools, mentoring students and helping them with their projects on the environment. He explains, "The youths I'm mentoring now, I hope they will become advocates to change the mentality and practices of Singaporeans. At the end of the day, the ground-up approach is the best way to change things."

Reflecting on his years of environmental advocacy, Chee Siang, who was awarded the EcoFriend award in 2008, says, "The YEE programme by NEA had a great impact on me. This belief in youths was very important, especially for me, who had come out of a boys' home. They didn't ask, why would I want a gangster on my committee? The people in 3P Partnership, they have touched and helped me. And because they have shaped me, now I can help shape the younger generation. This is my passion, to remember the people who moved me, and to move others."



"I find it really interesting when we go out to educate the public. Most people find it difficult to accept why teenagers will take up such activities. Sometimes, the public will avoid us because they think we are selling things, and they will go, no, no, no and walk off."
– Andy Wee, Litter-Free Ambassador

GOING ALL OUT AGAINST LITTER

Many teenagers would prefer spending their spare afternoons hanging out, learning the latest hip-hop moves or chasing the latest pop trends. But these youths from the Institute of Technical Education (ITE) College East would rather patrol the bus interchange and MRT stations near their school. Their mission: spread the litter-free message. If they spy a litterbug, they will politely ask the culprit to pick up his or her trash and bin it. Those who bin their trash get a cute token as encouragement.

These students are part of the Litter-Free Ambassador programme rolled out in 2010 by NEA. For years, NEA has been working with schools to run litter-free activities and nurturing students to keep the environment clean. Grooming student ambassadors to get out of their schools and into the community to combat littering marks a huge step forward. It is in fact, empowering students to take ownership of a clean environment and stand their ground against litterbugs.

At ITE College East, some 50 students enrolled in the programme in 2011. They are passionate about the environment, and want to do their bit in making Singapore cleaner. "I want to help the community and to set an example of not littering," says Jeffrey Din, one of the Litter-Free Ambassadors. "We go out in teams of 10 to 15 people, and patrol public areas. We spread the message, bin your litter, so that our environment can be clean and green."

Telling litter-bugs what to do, however, is not exactly a pleasant task. But these students are all up for it. Andy Wee enthuses, "I find it really interesting when we go out to educate the public. Most people find it difficult to accept why teenagers will take up such activities. Sometimes, the public will avoid us because they think we are selling things, and they will go, no, no, no and walk off." His fellow ambassador, Keith Kwa, is upbeat about the patrols, "Even if the litterbugs scold us, we just smile! At least I know what I'm doing is right. If they refuse to pick it, we pick up their garbage and throw it for them."

Still, to many youths, the idea comes across as odd. After all, much of our society is not used to taking a strong, public stance against littering. Keith shares, "Some of our friends would ask, 'Why are you doing this?' But after a while, some of them would join me, and slowly they get the hang of it."

Things are changing, slowly but surely. "We also patrol in the school," says Gay Yee Ying. "So we can see a small difference. Sometimes we see a student walking past litter, and stopping to pick it up and throw it into a bin." Keith agrees, "We know a small group has changed. We do see that around the school, and it is a form of motivation, when I see someone picking litter and binning it!"

Changing societal norms take time, and Singapore still has some way to go before littering becomes a true social no-no. These young litter-free ambassadors, however, are optimistic about their mission. Andy sums it up philosophically, "What we say, they do hear. But we don't really know if they take it to heart. But I think it's a matter of habit. If you keep doing something, other people will follow you. It will take time, it will be slow. Now, we are a minority trying to influence the majority, so it will take time for everyone to get the message."

RECOGNISING CHANGE-MAKERS

More and more, individuals from different walks of life are stepping up to contribute to our environment. These people put in time and effort, without any personal gain, to help bring about a clean and green Singapore. They touch the lives of many others, influencing people around them to care more for the environment.

Every bit of contribution makes a difference. Collectively, the efforts of such change-makers contribute to our long-term sustainability. To recognise these individuals, NEA launched the EcoFriend Award in 2007.

The award is given to those who have actively played a role in protecting, promoting and enhancing our environment. Recipients may come from the public and private sectors, NGOs, grassroots organisations and educational institutions. With the award, NEA hopes that EcoFriends are motivated to carry on their good work, and that more people will be inspired to emulate them.



